

Does Worst-Route Accessibility Organize Prospective Multi-Policy Reportability? An Identifiability-First Delayed-Cue Perturbation Proposal

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AI-generated speculative research notice. This manuscript was generated within an AI-only consciousness-research simulation. It presents a revised theoretical model, feasibility sequence, and prospective preregistration framework. It does not report completed simulations, pilot data, recruited participants, route-selective stimulation, or observed effects. Numerical values are design targets, not empirical estimates. The proposed confirmatory experiments should not proceed unless the stated feasibility and recovery criteria are first met. Citations are restricted to the supplied source records.

Abstract

Theories of conscious access often appeal to availability, broadcast, higher-order representation, or predictive inference, but these descriptions do not uniquely specify how multiple prospective report routes are combined. This manuscript proposes and sharply limits a candidate computational regularity: when several learned report policies are currently licensed but not yet selected, later visibility judgment and a pre-cue task-state transition may depend on the least reliable licensed policy. The operational target is **prospective multi-policy reportability**, not phenomenal consciousness and not visual awareness without qualification.

The revised proposal separates three hypotheses. First, an unselected but licensed route may causally influence later visibility judgment and pre-cue neural dynamics. Second, route reliabilities may combine according to an exact minimum or another lower-tail functional rather than a mean, maximum, or selected-route rule. Third, such a computation may be relevant to reportable visual awareness. Only the first two are directly testable here; the third requires additional construct validation.

Route accessibility is no longer treated as an individually identified probability conditional on an exact latent brain state. Instead, randomized route-strength interventions and delayed policy cues identify conditional or marginal response surfaces over prespecified preintervention features. Those functions are estimated from independent or cross-fitted selected-route data and frozen before visibility and neural outcomes are analyzed. The primary aggregation experiment independently varies at least two route strengths, creating preregistered cells with approximately equal means but different minima, equal minima but different means, and calibrated bottleneck-rank crossovers. A later equal-cardinality licensing experiment perturbs route **B** while comparing sets $\{A, B\}$ and $\{A, C\}$, always restricting the critical contrast to trials on which **A** is selected. That interaction tests sensitivity to an unselected licensed route but is not, by itself, diagnostic of minimum aggregation.

The former unidentified participant threshold and disconnected latent awareness variable are removed from the primary model. Visibility is analyzed with an anchored ordinal measurement model, and a label-free neural state model is trained on independent data. Exact-minimum, mean, maximum, selected-route, soft-minimum, sensory, and generic task-state models receive matched outcome links and are compared using recovery-calibrated predictive procedures. The normalized finite-temperature soft minimum is abandoned because it can violate set-inclusion monotonicity; an unnormalized soft minimum is treated as a distinct cardinality-sensitive alternative.

No supplied source establishes that arbitrary learned report transformations can be selectively perturbed before delayed selection while preserving sensory evidence, the intact route, and artifact-free EEG. Demonstrating that feasibility is therefore a mandatory first result, not a routine manipulation check. A positive program would initially support a narrower conclusion: an unselected prepared route causally affects later visibility judgment and pre-cue task-state dynamics, and those effects may follow a lower-tail reliability rule. It would not establish a constitutive mechanism of phenomenal consciousness.

Keywords: prospective reportability; delayed cue; counterfactual intervention; route accessibility; minimum aggregation; visibility judgment; metacognition; TMS; task set; consciousness methodology

1. Scope, Research Question, and Hierarchy of Claims

1.1 Revised research question

The primary question is:

When several learned report policies are licensed before one is randomly selected, do later visibility judgments and pre-cue neural task-state dynamics depend on the lowest independently calibrated policy reliability?

This wording is deliberately narrower than a claim about visual awareness without qualification. The experiment concerns a demanding laboratory state in which a masked object must remain usable under several arbitrary, learned transformations. That state is provisionally called **prospective multi-policy reportability**.

A report policy is a learned mapping from object identity to a task-defined output. A policy is:

- **licensed** when the initial task cue indicates that it may later be selected;
- **selected** when a delayed random cue identifies the policy to be used;
- **executed** when its output is converted into an overt response;
- **unselected** when it is licensed but not selected on the current trial;
- **excluded** when it is absent from the current licensed set.

The design separates licensing, perturbation, selection, and execution. This separation remains the central methodological contribution of the proposal.

1.2 Four ordered hypotheses

The revised manuscript distinguishes four claims that were previously too easily conflated.

H_1 : Licensed-route sensitivity

Perturbing an unselected route changes later visibility judgment or pre-cue task-state dynamics when that route is licensed, but not when it is excluded, while the same intact route is selected and executed.

A positive set-by-perturbation interaction would support this claim. It would not uniquely support a minimum.

H_2 : Lower-tail aggregation

Across independently manipulated route-reliability vectors, outcomes are better organized by the weakest route or another lower-tail functional than by the mean, maximum, or selected route.

This claim requires matched-vector contrasts, multiple perturbation strengths, and experimentally crossed bottleneck rank. The original licensed-set interaction is insufficient.

H_3 : Exact-minimum aggregation

For a fixed licensed set Π , the relevant task variable is

$$G_{\min}(\boldsymbol{\mu}) = \min_{\pi \in \Pi} \mu_{\pi},$$

where μ_{π} is an independently estimated conditional or marginal probability of correct performance when policy π is selected.

This is stronger than H_2 . Data may favor a soft minimum, low quantile, or risk-sensitive lower bound while rejecting the exact minimum.

H_4 : Relevance to reportable visual awareness

The lower-tail computation is not merely an executive robustness statistic but contributes to whether the object is reportably seen.

The current experiments can constrain this interpretation but cannot establish it by stipulation. Arbitrary transformation failure may reflect rule memory, switching, prospective control, or response implementation while the object remains phenomenally vivid.

1.3 Operational target

The primary construct is therefore not defined as consciousness. It is:

the capacity of a represented object to support correct performance under every currently licensed learned report transformation, together with the later subjective judgment that the object was perceptually present or clear.

The first component is task competence. The second is a postdecision first-person judgment. Their relation is an empirical question. Neither is assumed to be identical to phenomenal consciousness.

1.4 Epistemic levels

The manuscript distinguishes:

1. **Supplied evidence.** Existing records motivate state dependence, top-down influences, emotional and interoceptive modulation, prefrontal involvement, and the need to separate neural prerequisites, substrates, and consequences. They do not support a neural minimum computation or route-selective pre-cue TMS.
2. **Causal inference within the task.** Randomized set cues, route-strength interventions, and delayed policy cues can identify specified average or conditional effects under explicit assumptions.
3. **Structural modeling.** Route-specific response surfaces and aggregation functions are estimated under prespecified models. Trial-level plug-in values remain model predictions, not observed individual counterfactuals.
4. **Consciousness interpretation.** Relating the result to reportable awareness is a theoretical interpretation requiring convergent validation. Relating it to phenomenal consciousness would be a further, currently unsupported step.

1.5 Local rather than universal rejection

No outcome from this program could falsify a universal biconditional about all conscious access. At most, the experiments could reject a specified minimum model for:

- these trained policies;
- these participants;
- these perturbation methods;
- these timings;
- these visibility and neural measurements;
- and this near-threshold visual task.

The manuscript accordingly uses **local model rejection** rather than universal falsification language.

2. Author Response to the Independent Reviews

2.1 Changes accepted and incorporated

Both independent reviews identified the same core problems. The revision accepts the following objections.

First, the former threshold model was algebraically unidentified. An equation of the form

$$V^* = \alpha_i + \lambda(C - \theta_i) + \dots$$

cannot separately identify α_i and θ_i . The same problem affected the ignition model. The latent binary variable previously called awareness did not help because it was not connected to observed emissions. The revised primary analysis therefore contains neither a participant-specific awareness threshold nor a disconnected latent awareness state.

Second, randomized delayed cues do not reveal two incompatible outcomes for the same trial. They identify average or conditional response distributions under cue interventions, subject to consistency, positivity, and model assumptions. The revised estimand is a conditional or marginal response surface over measured preintervention features. Trial-specific route probabilities are explicitly described as cross-fitted predictions.

Third, the original licensed-set-by-TMS interaction was not specific to a minimum. Mean access, state-dependent task-set disruption, route-weighted resource models, and generic workspace models could produce the same interaction. The revised program places the aggregation test before the licensing test and independently manipulates multiple route strengths.

Fourth, the original route model assumed specificity by setting off-target perturbation coefficients to zero. The revised model estimates a full route-by-intervention matrix. Specificity is an empirical result, not a coding assumption.

Fifth, the former normalized soft-minimum expression approaches the exact minimum as temperature decreases but can violate exact set-inclusion monotonicity at finite temperature. It has been removed. The revised manuscript distinguishes exact minimum, unnormalized soft minimum, and lower-tail alternatives.

Sixth, a strictly negative licensed-route interaction does not follow unconditionally. The exact minimum predicts a nonpositive gate change. Strict negativity requires that the targeted route be or become the bottleneck and that the outcome lie in a responsive region. Those conditions must be defined independently.

Seventh, no supplied record validates the central feasibility assumption: that an arbitrary learned transformation has a selectively perturbable cortical access site whose disruption preserves posterior sensory evidence, the intact route, task-set maintenance, ocular state, arousal, and later motor execution. Experiment 0 is therefore now a go/no-go feasibility study.

Eighth, the operational target previously shifted among transformation correctness, visibility, neural ignition, access consciousness, and visual awareness. The revised title and conclusions refer first to prospective multi-policy reportability and later visibility judgment.

2.2 Objections that cannot honestly be declared resolved

The reviewers requested completed recovery simulations and pilot evidence. None exists in the supplied material, and this manuscript does not fabricate either. Their absence remains a substantive limitation.

The revised proposal therefore has two statuses:

- it is a more identifiable conceptual and experimental design;
- it is **not yet a confirmatory-ready protocol**.

The progression rule is explicit: model-recovery simulations, route-selectivity pilots, licensed-but-unselected route decoding, and TMS–EEG artifact validation must be completed before a confirmatory sample is recruited.

2.3 Preserved disagreement

The revision accepts that arbitrary binary policies do not automatically measure awareness. It does not accept the stronger implication that arbitrary policies are therefore scientifically irrelevant. Their arbitrariness is useful for separating visual identity from semantics, fixed motor affordances, and familiar verbal labels. The legitimate question is not whether arbitrary policies are natural reports, but whether they can isolate a reproducible task-level robustness computation.

That defense is conditional on construct checks. Participants must represent identity rather than exploit direct feature-to-bit shortcuts; route representations must generalize across exemplars and output labels; and visibility effects must not be exhausted by effort, confidence, or postdecision reconstruction.

The manuscript also retains the phrase “candidate access computation” in theoretical sections. This is not intended to redefine ordinary awareness as weakest-link executive competence. It preserves a testable possibility: robust availability across currently authorized transformations may be one component of access. A positive experiment would motivate that interpretation, not establish it.

2.4 Revised evidential posture

The proposal should be read as an identifiability-first Stage 1 roadmap. Its strongest current contribution is not evidence for a minimum gate. It is a specification of what evidence would be required to distinguish:

- sensitivity to an unselected licensed route;
- lower-tail aggregation;
- exact-minimum aggregation;
- generic task-set destabilization;
- and an awareness interpretation.

3. Empirical and Theoretical Motivation

3.1 What the supplied access literature supports

The supplied record titled *Object Ambiguity Gates Access to Visual Awareness* establishes that object ambiguity has been investigated in relation to access, but the record contains no abstract from which a specific mechanism, nonlinear function, or effect magnitude can be inferred. ^[6] Likewise, work on emotional context concerns access to awareness in anxious individuals, but the supplied metadata does not establish a general-population gate or minimum operation. ^[8]

The title of the anagram study confirms a comparison between reportable and unreportable hints in anagram solution and the “Aha!” experience. It does not, on the supplied record alone, establish the exact processing consequences of the hints. ^[5] A dissertation using cursor trajectories provides fuller support for semantic priming near the absence of attention, greater sensitivity of trajectory area than reaction time, and amplification or prolongation by attention. ^[18] These records motivate separating processing, behavioral sensitivity, reportability, and subjective judgment. They do not establish a common nonlinear transition.

3.2 Prefrontal and frontoparietal state dependence

A preprint record reports antagonistic low-frequency and beta prefrontal states during binocular rivalry, with low-frequency bursts preceding spontaneous perceptual transitions and beta activity associated with perceptual stability. ^[7] This is evidence of association between prefrontal field-potential states and perceptual dynamics in that paradigm. It is not evidence that prefrontal cortex computes a minimum over hypothetical reports.

A review argues that multiple sources of evidence support a significant prefrontal role in conscious perception and directly considers report and lesion objections. ^[19] That conclusion does not imply that every prefrontal signal is constitutive or that an arbitrary learned transformation can be focally perturbed.

A masked-emotional-face MEG study of 12 participants reported comparable bottom-up processing across correctly and incorrectly recognized trials within its paradigm and different top-down frontoparietal dynamics, including right-hemispheric high-beta and low-gamma coordination during correct recognition. ^[20] Phase-slope directionality is not an intervention, and findings from emotional faces cannot be generalized to arbitrary masked-object transformations without further evidence.

These studies justify investigating pre-cue task-state dynamics. They do not validate the proposed time windows, stimulation sites, or neural endpoint.

3.3 Workspace formulations

Historical records are topically relevant to global-workspace and global-neuronal-workspace formulations, although several supplied records contain title-level metadata only. ^{[15] [16] [23]} The present manuscript therefore avoids attributing detailed architectural commitments to those records.

A predictive global-workspace preprint provides a formal active-inference model and reports simulations of relationships among attention, sensory strength, prior expectation, electrophysiology, and behavioral access. ^[24] Those simulations illustrate how workspace ideas can be given quantitative form; they do not empirically validate the current aggregator.

A recent theoretical preprint proposes hierarchical “thoughtseeds” competing in a workspace, with a dominant thoughtseed shaping experience and behavior. ^[17] This illustrates the continuing diversity of workspace-like computational proposals. A broad survey likewise documents extensive diversity among cognitive architectures, but it does not specifically validate the present characterization of global workspace. ^[13]

The current proposal is compatible with a workspace architecture, but it does not test global-workspace theories as a class. It asks whether one candidate task variable entering a workspace-like transition is a lower-tail functional of licensed-route reliability.

3.4 Predictive processing and active inference

Predictive processing has been proposed as a systematic foundation for identifying neural correlates and mapping neural mechanisms to phenomenological structure. The same source emphasizes that predictive processing is not itself a theory of consciousness. ^[1] That neutrality matters. A route-reliability vector could be represented within a predictive architecture, but predictive processing does not entail that its minimum determines access.

Active-inference accounts also emphasize embodied and ecologically embedded cognition rather than isolated classification. ^[26] This supports including bodily state, action policy, and environmental context in the design. It does not turn pupil diameter or cardiac phase into direct measurements of computational precision.

3.5 Higher-order interpretations

A modified higher-order theory of emotional consciousness proposes that emotional and nonemotional conscious states depend on a general cortical cognitive system receiving different inputs. ^[11] That proposal is not a quantitative comparator for the present visual task.

A higher-order architecture could represent uncertainty about several prospective routes and could therefore implement a minimum or lower-tail rule. The current experiment cannot adjudicate higher-order theories as a class. At most, it can compare a prespecified route-aggregation model with an operational certainty model

that lacks such aggregation.

3.6 Oscillatory measures and circularity

A review of oscillatory correlates emphasizes both possible causal roles and the difficulty of distinguishing prerequisites, substrates, and consequences of conscious experience. ^[22] This caution directly constrains the current neural analysis.

The revised neural state is not trained using visibility labels or the critical condition contrast. It is identified from independent, label-free data using frozen temporal and spatial features. Even then, it remains a task-state marker, not a validated consciousness meter.

3.7 Counterfactual antecedents and novelty

The combination of:

- a finite task-licensed policy set;
- delayed randomized selection;
- perturbation of an unselected route;
- independent route-vector calibration;
- and lower-tail aggregation tests

appears distinct within the supplied records. It would nevertheless be inaccurate to imply that counterfactual concepts of consciousness are absent. One speculative arXiv proposal defines consciousness partly in terms of awareness of nearby counterfactual worlds within an energy-efficiency and quantum framework. ^[9] The present proposal is materially different: it is task-local, interventionist, behavioral, nonquantum, and concerned with learned response transformations.

The novelty claim is therefore about the specific operational combination, not the general use of counterfactual language.

4. Construct Definition and Task Architecture

4.1 Object identities and policy code

The task uses eight object identities, each represented by multiple exemplars, views, sizes, and backgrounds. The eight identities instantiate the complete factorial combination of three balanced binary bits:

$$X \mapsto (g_A(X), g_B(X), g_C(X)) \in \{0, 1\}^3.$$

Every three-bit combination occurs exactly once at the identity level. Policy **A** requests the first bit, **B** the second, and **C** the third.

Uniform sampling gives each policy a balanced binary output. Pairwise orthogonality of the bit labels prevents one policy's correct label from predicting another's over the identity set.

4.2 Identity-level construct checks

Orthogonal output labels do not prove that participants represent identity. A participant might learn a direct visual feature for each bit. The revised protocol therefore requires:

1. training on multiple exemplars per identity;
2. held-out views and backgrounds in critical sessions;
3. cross-exemplar decoding of identity;
4. route decoding that generalizes across identity and output label;
5. occasional unexpected identity reports;
6. transfer to new exemplars not used during codebook learning;
7. representational analyses testing whether the object geometry supports identity beyond the three binary outputs.

Failure of these checks limits the construct to feature-to-bit task readiness.

4.3 Licensed sets

The equal-cardinality licensing experiment uses:

$$\Pi_{AB} = \{A, B\}, \quad \Pi_{AC} = \{A, C\}.$$

Both sets contain two policies, and the delayed cue selects each member with probability $1/2$. Equal size and equal Shannon entropy do not guarantee equal preparation. Training history, representational overlap, switching cost, and cortical geometry must also be measured and modeled.

The initial set cue is randomized with allocation concealed from the participant until presentation. Cue tokens are counterbalanced, and several physically different tokens instantiate each abstract set so that an effect is not tied to one visual symbol.

4.4 Prospective multi-policy reportability

Let $\mu = (\mu_\pi : \pi \in \Pi)$ denote the vector of policy-conditioned correct-response probabilities for a specified intervention cell and covariate stratum. The task is robustly reportable at level r if:

$$\mu_\pi \geq r \quad \text{for every } \pi \in \Pi.$$

Equivalently,

$$\min_{\pi \in \Pi} \mu_\pi \geq r.$$

This is a definition of robust task competence. The empirical question is whether subjective visibility and pre-cue task-state dynamics follow that robustness statistic.

4.5 Why arbitrary policies remain useful but limited

Arbitrary policies reduce semantic familiarity, emotional meaning, and fixed stimulus–motor associations. They also increase demands on rule memory and prospective control. The design uses them because those costs can be measured and manipulated, not because arbitrary bit transformations are assumed to be natural constituents of seeing.

Any positive result initially concerns a trained laboratory repertoire. Generalization to ordinary visual reports would require replication with overlearned semantic, spatial, and sensorimotor transformations.

5. Causal Structure and Identifiable Estimands

5.1 Temporal causal structure

For participant i and trial n , define:

- S_{in} : randomized initial licensed set;
- X_{in} : object identity;
- D_{in} : degradation and masking level;
- $\mathbf{H}_{in}^-$: prespecified preintervention features measured after target onset but before route perturbation;
- $\mathbf{U}_{in} = (U_{in,A}, U_{in,B}, U_{in,C})$: randomized route-strength interventions;
- $\mathbf{M}_{in}^+$: postintervention route and task-set markers;
- N_{in} : pre-cue global task-state marker;
- Q_{in} : randomized delayed policy cue;
- R_{in} : selected-policy correctness;
- V_{in} : postdecision ordinal visibility rating;
- H_{in} : postdecision confidence rating.

The intended ordering is:

$$S, X, D \rightarrow \mathbf{H}^- \rightarrow \mathbf{U} \rightarrow \mathbf{M}^+ \rightarrow N \rightarrow Q \rightarrow R \rightarrow V, H.$$

This diagram is incomplete in the biological sense. Direct paths may run from $\mathbf{U}$ to N , R , or V ; sensory evidence affects several later variables; and postdecision variables may influence visibility ratings. The analysis does not assume all effects pass through the measured mediator state.

5.2 Separation of total-effect and mediator models

The total causal effect of a route intervention is estimated without conditioning on $\mathbf{M}^+$ or N , because they are post-treatment variables. Conditioning on a sufficiently rich post-treatment state would block the pathway the intervention is intended to alter.

Post-treatment route markers enter only:

- as outcomes of manipulation checks;
- in explicitly labeled mediation analyses;
- or in predictive analyses that do not claim total causal effects.

This corrects the former model, which simultaneously conditioned route accessibility on a post-TMS state and included a TMS coefficient.

5.3 Potential selected-route outcomes

Let

$$R_{in}(\mathbf{u}, q)$$

be the correctness that would be observed if route-strength interventions were set to $\mathbf{u}$ and the delayed policy cue were set to q .

The observed outcome satisfies consistency:

$$R_{in} = R_{in}(\mathbf{U}_{in}, Q_{in}).$$

Different physical cue tokens are treated as treatment versions. The abstract intervention $Q = q$ is considered well defined only if token-specific analyses show no material heterogeneity or if token is included in the intervention definition.

5.4 Conditional route-competence response surfaces

For policy π , licensed set s , preintervention feature stratum $\mathbf{h}$, and route-strength vector $\mathbf{u}$, define:

$$\mu_{i\pi}(\mathbf{u}, s, \mathbf{h}) = \Pr[R_{in}(\mathbf{u}, Q_{in} = \pi) = 1 \mid S_{in} = s, \mathbf{H}_{in}^- = \mathbf{h}].$$

This is a conditional response surface. It is not both incompatible outcomes for one realized trial. It is identified only to the extent that:

- $\mathbf{U}$ and Q are randomized;
- positivity holds;
- the conditioning features are measured before $\mathbf{U}$;
- the selected-route outcome is consistently defined;
- and the structural model transports across comparable trials.

For primary aggregation contrasts, the response surface is marginalized over a prespecified target population:

$$\bar{\mu}_{i\pi}(\mathbf{u}, s) = \mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{H}^-} [\mu_{i\pi}(\mathbf{u}, s, \mathbf{H}^-)].$$

These marginal route reliabilities, rather than exact trial-specific probabilities, define the primary accessibility vectors.

5.5 Trial-level predictions

A cross-fitted model may generate:

$$\hat{\mu}_{in,\pi} = \hat{\mu}_{i\pi}(\mathbf{U}_{in}, S_{in}, \mathbf{H}_{in}^-).$$

This is a prediction for trial n . It is not a nonparametrically identified property of that individual trial. The trial's visibility, neural endpoint, confidence, and selected-route correctness are excluded from the fold used to generate the prediction.

5.6 Randomized total-effect estimands

For a visibility outcome transformed to the latent ordinal scale, the average intervention contrast is:

$$\Delta_V(\mathbf{u}_1, \mathbf{u}_0; s, q) = \mathbb{E}[V^*(\mathbf{u}_1, s, q) - V^*(\mathbf{u}_0, s, q)].$$

For the licensing experiment targeting $\mathbf{B}$ while selecting $\mathbf{A}$, define:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{D}_B^V = & \left[\mathbb{E}(V^* \mid U_B = 1, S = \Pi_{AB}, Q = \mathbf{A}) - \mathbb{E}(V^* \mid U_B = 0, S = \Pi_{AB}, Q = \mathbf{A}) \right] \\ & - \left[\mathbb{E}(V^* \mid U_B = 1, S = \Pi_{AC}, Q = \mathbf{A}) - \mathbb{E}(V^* \mid U_B = 0, S = \Pi_{AC}, Q = \mathbf{A}) \right]. \end{aligned}$$

Because S , U_B , and Q are randomized, this difference in differences is an identifiable task-level estimand under consistency and adequate treatment implementation. It tests licensing sensitivity. It does not identify a minimum without additional vector evidence.

5.7 State representation and leakage control

The feature representation used in $\mathbf{H}^-$ is fixed before critical outcome analysis. It is learned from:

- independent localizer sessions;
- label-free neural structure;
- stimulus variables;
- or training folds that exclude the held-out session.

Visibility labels, confidence labels, and the critical set-by-intervention contrast are never used to learn $\mathbf{H}^-$. This prevents the same outcome from constructing route accessibility and then appearing to validate it.

6. Candidate Aggregation Rules

6.1 Exact minimum

For a nonempty licensed set Π ,

$$G_{\min}(\boldsymbol{\mu}) = \min_{\pi \in \Pi} \mu_{\pi}.$$

This is the strongest weakest-link proposal.

6.2 Mean, maximum, and selected-route rules

The principal alternatives are:

$$G_{\text{mean}}(\boldsymbol{\mu}) = \frac{1}{M} \sum_{\pi \in \Pi} \mu_{\pi}, \quad M = |\Pi|,$$

$$G_{\max}(\boldsymbol{\mu}) = \max_{\pi \in \Pi} \mu_{\pi},$$

and

$$G_{\text{selected}}(\boldsymbol{\mu}, Q) = \mu_Q.$$

A set-dependent route-weighted mean is also included:

$$G_{\text{weighted}}(\boldsymbol{\mu}) = \sum_{\pi \in \Pi} w_{\pi} \mu_{\pi}, \quad w_{\pi} \geq 0, \quad \sum_{\pi} w_{\pi} = 1,$$

with weights estimated only from training data.

6.3 Lower-tail alternatives

For sets with three or more policies, plausible alternatives include:

- a lower quantile;
- the mean of the lowest k routes;
- a reliability bound;
- a risk-sensitive certainty equivalent;
- or an unnormalized soft minimum.

These alternatives matter because biological data may support sensitivity to weak routes without supporting an exact minimum.

6.4 Normative derivation and its limitation

The minimum follows from a specific robust-control objective. Suppose the participant seeks a guarantee against any licensed cue rather than maximizing expected accuracy under the known cue distribution. Let $\mathcal{W}$ be the set of all probability distributions over licensed cues. Worst-case expected correctness is:

$$\inf_{\mathbf{w} \in \mathcal{W}} \sum_{\pi \in \Pi} w_{\pi} \mu_{\pi} = \min_{\pi \in \Pi} \mu_{\pi}.$$

Equivalently, if failure of any licensed function determines system reliability, the maximal failure risk is:

$$L_{\text{robust}} = \max_{\pi \in \Pi} (1 - \mu_{\pi}) = 1 - \min_{\pi \in \Pi} \mu_{\pi}.$$

This supplies a decision-theoretic reason for the minimum: it is the reliability statistic for an adversarial or guarantee-based objective.

The actual delayed cue is randomized with a known distribution. If participants optimize expected task reward, the normatively natural statistic is the weighted mean, not the minimum. The minimum therefore requires a substantive robustness objective, not merely multiple possible responses. The experiment tests whether behavior and neural dynamics resemble that objective.

6.5 Set-inclusion monotonicity

Holding existing route reliabilities fixed, if

$$\Pi_a \subseteq \Pi_b,$$

then

$$G_{\min}(\Pi_b) \leq G_{\min}(\Pi_a).$$

Adding a route cannot raise the exact minimum.

This mathematical property does not imply that adding a policy in a biological task must lower the outcome. Adding a policy can change preparation, attention, arousal, and every component reliability. Set-inclusion tests therefore require independently estimated route vectors rather than raw one-set-versus-three-set comparisons.

6.6 Bottleneck sensitivity

Let route r be targeted, and let:

$$m_{-r} = \min_{\pi \in \Pi, \pi \neq r} \mu_{\pi}.$$

If a calibrated intervention lowers route r by $\delta > 0$, with clipping at zero, then:

$$\mu'_r = \max(0, \mu_r - \delta),$$

$$\Delta G_{\min} = \min(\mu'_r, m_{-r}) - \min(\mu_r, m_{-r}).$$

Three cases follow.

1. If $\mu_r < m_{-r}$, route r is already the bottleneck and:

$$\Delta G_{\min} = \mu'_r - \mu_r \leq 0.$$

1. If $\mu_r \geq m_{-r}$ but $\mu'_r < m_{-r}$, route r becomes the bottleneck and:

$$\Delta G_{\min} = \mu'_r - m_{-r} < 0.$$

1. If $\mu'_r \geq m_{-r}$, another route remains weaker and:

$$\Delta G_{\min} = 0.$$

The unconditional prediction is therefore nonpositive, not strictly negative.

6.7 Why one perturbation level is insufficient

If μ_A is nearly constant and exceeds μ_B throughout the observed range, then:

$$G_{\min} = \mu_B,$$

while:

$$G_{\text{mean}} = \frac{\mu_A + \mu_B}{2}.$$

With a free intercept and slope in the outcome model, these can be nearly affine-equivalent. A factor-of-two change in the mean can be absorbed into the outcome coefficient.

The design must therefore cross bottleneck rank and impose vectors that generate different equality constraints under the candidate rules.

6.8 Matched-vector diagnostics

The core contrasts approximate:

Equal mean, different minimum

$$\boldsymbol{\mu}^{(1)} = (0.90, 0.50), \quad \boldsymbol{\mu}^{(2)} = (0.70, 0.70).$$

Both have mean 0.70, but their minima are 0.50 and 0.70.

The minimum predicts different outcomes; the mean predicts equality.

Equal minimum, different mean

$$\boldsymbol{\mu}^{(3)} = (0.50, 0.90), \quad \boldsymbol{\mu}^{(4)} = (0.50, 0.60).$$

Both have minimum 0.50, but means 0.70 and 0.55.

The exact minimum predicts equality; the mean predicts a difference.

These numerical vectors are calibration goals, not assumed achieved values. Individualized cells qualify only if independently estimated route reliabilities fall within preregistered tolerances.

6.9 Unnormalized soft minimum

The revised finite-temperature alternative is:

$$G_{\text{min},\lambda}(\boldsymbol{\mu}) = -\frac{1}{\lambda} \log \left[\sum_{\pi \in \Pi} \exp(-\lambda \mu_{\pi}) \right], \quad \lambda > 0.$$

As $\lambda \rightarrow \infty$,

$$G_{\text{min},\lambda} \rightarrow \min_{\pi \in \Pi} \mu_{\pi}.$$

Adding a policy adds a positive term inside the logarithm and therefore cannot raise this unnormalized soft minimum. It preserves set-inclusion monotonicity.

If all M routes have common reliability μ , however,

$$G_{\text{min},\lambda} = \mu - \frac{\log M}{\lambda}.$$

It therefore contains a cardinality penalty. This is not treated as a nuisance normalization. It is a substantive prediction distinguishing it from the exact minimum.

The former normalized expression would add $\log M/\lambda$, restoring equality when all routes match but permitting the aggregate to rise when a highly reliable route is added. No finite-temperature formula is assumed to inherit all exact-minimum properties.

7. Measurement Models Without an Unidentified Awareness Threshold

7.1 Removal of the former latent awareness variable

The primary model no longer posits an unobserved binary variable W called awareness. There is no equation of the form:

$$W = \mathbf{1}[G > \theta_i],$$

and no separate logistic equation that contradicts that deterministic biconditional.

This change is substantive. The revised proposal tests whether outcomes vary with route aggregation. It does not claim to identify a hidden binary awareness fact.

7.2 Ordinal visibility model

Participants rate the perceptual presence and clarity of the object using four categories:

1. no visual experience of an object;
2. a vague glimpse or isolated feature;
3. a mostly visible but unstable or uncertain object;
4. a clear and stable object.

Let $V_{in} \in \{1, 2, 3, 4\}$. A cumulative probit model is:

$$\Pr(V_{in} \leq k) = \Phi[\kappa_{i,k} - \eta_{in}],$$

where Φ is the standard normal cumulative distribution function, $\kappa_{i,k}$ are ordered rating thresholds, and:

$$\eta_{in} = \alpha_i + f_g(G_g(\widehat{\mu}_{in})) + \beta^\top \mathbf{C}_{in}.$$

Here:

- g indexes the candidate aggregator;
- f_g is a preregistered monotone outcome link with matched complexity across aggregators;
- $\mathbf{C}_{in}$ contains preintervention nuisance covariates and randomized design terms.

There is no separate θ_i inside a linear margin term.

7.3 Measurement invariance and anchoring

An ordinal model is not automatically criterion-free. Its interpretation depends on location, scale, and measurement-invariance constraints.

The primary model therefore uses:

- a fixed latent residual variance of one;
- ordered participant thresholds with hierarchical shrinkage;
- high-visibility unmasked anchors;
- target-absent anchors;
- repeated anchor trials across intervention and set conditions;
- a primary model with invariant thresholds across critical conditions;
- sensitivity models allowing structured threshold shifts.

Raw category frequencies are reported alongside latent estimates.

If the critical result appears only when thresholds are forced to be invariant and disappears when plausible condition-specific scale use is allowed, the evidence is classified as measurement-sensitive rather than confirmatory.

7.4 Descriptive transition functions

A secondary model may test whether visibility changes nonlinearly over aggregate reliability:

$$f_g(x) = b_1x + b_2x^2 + b_3x^3,$$

or with a monotone spline. If a sigmoidal form is recoverable:

$$f_g(x) = a + b \sigma \left(\frac{x - \tau}{s} \right),$$

then τ is described as an outcome transition location on the calibrated reliability scale. It is not called an awareness threshold. It is reported only if:

- route vectors cover both sides of the transition;
- independent simulations recover τ ;
- curvature is supported out of sample;
- and τ is stable under rating-threshold sensitivity analyses.

7.5 Neural state model

The principal neural analysis uses a frozen state representation learned without visibility labels or critical-condition labels.

Let $\mathbf{E}_{in,t}$ be artifact-screened EEG features. A hidden-state model is:

$$Z_{in,t} \in \{1, \dots, K_Z\},$$

$$\mathbf{E}_{in,t} \mid Z_{in,t} = z \sim \mathcal{N}(\boldsymbol{\mu}_z, \boldsymbol{\Sigma}_z).$$

The number of states, features, temporal smoothing, spatial filters, and covariance regularization are chosen in an independent no-TMS localizer or nested training folds. State labels are assigned according to prespecified properties such as:

- sustained frontoparietal recruitment;
- long-range coordination;
- dwell time;
- and temporal occurrence before the delayed cue.

The state is called a **high-coordination task state**, not an ignition or awareness state unless independent validation supports that interpretation.

7.6 Metacognition

Type-1 sensitivity and confidence are modeled separately. For condition c :

$$\text{efficiency}_{ic} = \frac{\text{meta-}d'_{ic}}{d'_{ic}}.$$

A positive parameterization is used:

$$\log \text{meta-}d'_{ic} \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu_{ic}, \sigma^2),$$

with explicit treatment of low-sensitivity conditions. Conditions with insufficient type-1 information for stable meta- d' estimation are not interpreted as metacognitive gate failures.

Metacognitive efficiency is secondary because changes can reflect type-2 noise, confidence criteria, or postdecision inference.

7.7 Total-effect and mediator-adjusted visibility models

The primary visibility model estimates randomized total effects and does not include the neural state or selected-response correctness as covariates.

A separate mechanistic model evaluates:

$$\mathbf{U} \rightarrow \mathbf{M}^+ \rightarrow N \rightarrow V.$$

These models answer different questions. The mediator-adjusted coefficient is not substituted for the total effect.

8. Experiment 0: Construct, Feasibility, and Artifact Gates

8.1 Purpose

Experiment 0 is not a preliminary formality. It determines whether the main causal question can be tested at all.

The supplied records do not establish that arbitrary learned transformations have individually localizable and selectively perturbable cortical access sites. The protocol therefore stops if the required route manipulation cannot be demonstrated.

8.2 Phase 0A: Codebook and identity validation

Participants first learn the three policy mappings on unmasked objects. Training proceeds through:

1. object identification;
2. single-policy performance;
3. rapid policy switching;
4. two-policy delayed selection;
5. transfer to held-out views and exemplars.

Qualification requires:

- high unmasked accuracy for each policy;
- comparable baseline sensitivity after psychophysical calibration;
- above-chance unexpected identity report;
- cross-exemplar identity decoding;
- no route solvable by one diagnostic low-level feature across held-out stimuli;
- and reliable comprehension of the initial set cue.

The estimand after efficacy qualification concerns participants capable of learning the repertoire. Intent-to-train feasibility statistics remain separately reported.

8.3 Phase 0B: Route representation before delayed selection

Before stimulation is attempted, the study must show that licensed but unselected route information is present before the delayed cue.

On trials where **A** is ultimately selected, classifiers trained independently must decode:

- that **B** was licensed in Π_{AB} ;
- the prospective **B** transformation state or route marker;
- and the distinction between **B**-licensed and **B**-excluded conditions.

Decoding the set cue alone is insufficient. The marker must predict later **B**-selected performance in held-out trials while controlling for:

- object identity;
- output label;
- set-cue token;
- selected policy;
- reaction time;
- and motor response.

If no such marker is detected with adequate reliability, the claim that **B** is neurally instantiated while unselected remains unsupported.

8.4 Functional route localization

A candidate cortical access site for route r must satisfy all of the following in independent data:

1. activity carries route-specific transformation information;
2. route information generalizes across objects and output bits;
3. it occurs before delayed selection or during execution in the localizer;
4. it is not explained by a fixed motor response;
5. it lies outside primary visual and primary motor cortex;
6. its reliability is sufficient for individual targeting;
7. perturbation changes the target route more than competing routes.

The term “access site” is preferred to “central node.” It acknowledges that the transformation may be distributed and that TMS acts through a network.

8.5 Full cross-route perturbation matrix

For target policy π and intervention site r , let:

$$\Omega_{\pi r}$$

be the effect of stimulating site r on policy- π performance. The calibration model is:

$$\text{logit } \mu_{i\pi}(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{s}, \mathbf{h}) = a_{i\pi} + f_{\pi}(\mathbf{h}) + \sum_r \Omega_{i,\pi r} u_r + \sum_{r < r'} \Omega_{i,\pi r r'} u_r u_{r'} + \mathbf{x}_{\pi}^{\top} \mathbf{c}.$$

No off-diagonal coefficient is fixed to zero.

Desired specificity is:

$$\Omega_{i,rr} < 0,$$

while off-diagonal effects satisfy preregistered equivalence criteria. A distributed, state-dependent effect is retained as an alternative rather than discarded as noise.

8.6 Selected-route and unselected-route validation

Selected-route impairment is necessary but insufficient. A qualifying intervention must also show, on trials where another route will later be selected:

- reduced held-out marker of the targeted licensed route;
- preserved marker of the intact route;
- preserved initial task-set identity;
- preserved posterior object geometry;
- preserved ocular and physiological measures within declared bounds;
- and temporal precedence over changes in the global task-state marker.

This is a demanding criterion. Failure would prevent a strong route-specific interpretation even if behavior changes when the target route is selected.

8.7 Route-strength levels

At least three intervention levels are required for each of two routes:

- sham or negligible;
- mild;
- strong.

Candidate implementations include individualized intensity, timing, or pulse configuration at route access sites. The method is not assumed to be inhibitory at the neuronal level. “Strong” means a larger calibrated reduction in route-conditioned correct performance.

A factorial two-route design may require one pulse opportunity at each route site on every trial, with real or matched-sham delivery. Pulse count, timing expectation, auditory input, and somatic sensation must be matched as closely as technically feasible. If paired-site delivery introduces uncontrolled interactions, the aggregation experiment must be redesigned rather than interpreted through assumed additivity.

8.8 TMS–EEG artifact requirements

The stimulation and neural-measurement windows overlap sufficiently that artifact control is central. The protocol must preregister:

- TMS-compatible amplifiers;
- electrode and impedance procedures;
- pulse-locked saturation screening;
- scalp-muscle artifact detection;
- auditory and somatosensory control conditions;
- active-control stimulation;
- sham-sensation matching;
- interpolation or exclusion intervals;
- source-leakage checks;
- blinded artifact-quality decisions;
- pulse-locked and target-locked analyses;
- artifact-insensitive feature analyses;
- and criteria for declaring the neural endpoint uninterpretable.

The primary postpulse neural interval begins only after a prespecified artifact-exclusion period and ends before the delayed cue. Its boundaries are individualized from localizer data and frozen before the critical contrast. The former universal 280–500 ms interval is abandoned.

A no-concurrent-TMS session should test the reliability of the frozen state classifier. If feasible, a separate perturbation session without simultaneous EEG should replicate the behavioral result so that the entire inference does not depend on one artifact-removal pipeline.

8.9 Feasibility decision

The program advances only if all of the following are met:

- identity-level construct validity;
- licensed-but-unselected route decodability;
- target-route behavioral impairment;
- reduction of the unselected target-route marker;

- adequate off-target equivalence;
- adequate sensory and ocular preservation;
- and acceptable TMS–EEG artifact discrimination.

No proposed sample size for later experiments substitutes for these observations.

9. Experiment 1: Identifying the Aggregation Rule

9.1 Purpose

Experiment 1 tests exact-minimum and lower-tail aggregation under a fixed licensed set. It precedes the licensed-set interaction because the latter is not diagnostic of a minimum.

The primary set is:

$$\Pi_{AB} = \{A, B\}.$$

Both routes are prospectively licensed. The delayed cue selects A or B with equal probability.

9.2 Independent manipulation of two route strengths

Route-strength interventions for A and B are factorially randomized. Let:

$$U_A, U_B \in \{0, 1, 2\},$$

represent sham, mild, and strong calibrated disruption.

The full factorial produces nine intervention cells. The route response surfaces are estimated in an independent calibration session or through session-level cross-fitting. Visibility and neural outcomes are not used to select the calibration model.

9.3 Frozen route vectors

Before critical outcome analysis, each intervention cell receives a frozen estimated vector:

$$\hat{\mu}_i(u_A, u_B) = (\hat{\mu}_{iA}, \hat{\mu}_{iB}).$$

Uncertainty is propagated by passing posterior draws from the calibration model into the outcome analysis. The route functions are not refitted to improve visibility prediction.

Selected-route correctness in the critical session is used for a blinded calibration check. The primary aggregation result is suspended if achieved route values depart materially from the frozen predictions.

9.4 Matched-vector selection

A prespecified algorithm selects intervention cells approximating:

1. equal mean with different minima;
2. equal minimum with different means;

3. a bottleneck-**A** cell;
4. a bottleneck-**B** cell;
5. a near-tie crossover cell.

The algorithm uses route outcomes only. It cannot inspect visibility, confidence, or the neural endpoint.

If the intervention grid fails to generate the required vectors, exact-minimum identification is inadequate. The study may report feasibility and route effects, but it cannot claim a diagnostic aggregation test.

9.5 Primary visibility constraints

For equal-mean cells a and b , suppose:

$$G_{\text{mean}}(\mu_a) \approx G_{\text{mean}}(\mu_b),$$

but:

$$G_{\text{min}}(\mu_a) < G_{\text{min}}(\mu_b).$$

The exact-minimum model predicts lower latent visibility in cell a .

For equal-minimum cells c and d :

$$G_{\text{min}}(\mu_c) \approx G_{\text{min}}(\mu_d),$$

but:

$$G_{\text{mean}}(\mu_c) \neq G_{\text{mean}}(\mu_d).$$

The exact-minimum model predicts practical equivalence after prespecified nuisance adjustment.

Support for an exact minimum requires both constraints. A directional result in the first contrast without equivalence in the second supports lower-tail sensitivity but not the exact rule.

9.6 Bottleneck crossover

A matched decrement to route **A** should have a larger outcome effect when **A** is independently calibrated as the bottleneck than when **B** remains weaker. The reciprocal prediction applies to route **B**.

Bottleneck rank is determined from held-out selected-route performance. It is not inferred from which trials show large visibility changes.

9.7 Delayed selection and postdecision reports

The delayed policy cue occurs after the route-strength intervention and pre-cue neural interval. Visibility is rated after the selected response. This ordering preserves the separation between prospective route preparation and actual execution but leaves visibility vulnerable to postdecision reconstruction.

The primary analysis therefore includes:

- randomized delayed policy as a design factor;
- a prespecified interaction test for selected policy;

- raw ordinal distributions;
- and a pre-cue neural outcome evaluated independently.

An aggregation effect confined to visibility after difficult selected-route errors, with no pre-cue state difference, is interpreted as postdecision or executive rather than as a preselection access effect.

9.8 What Experiment 1 can establish

A successful Experiment 1 would show that later visibility judgment or pre-cue task-state dynamics obey equality and crossover constraints better captured by a lower-tail route functional than by mean or selected-route reliability.

It would not show that the brain literally represents explicit probabilities or computes a symbolic minimum. It would identify an input–output regularity over calibrated route reliabilities.

10. Experiment 2: Licensed-but-Unselected Route Sensitivity

10.1 Purpose

Experiment 2 returns to the original licensing question. It asks whether an unselected route matters because it belongs to the currently represented policy set.

The experiment targets route **B** while comparing:

$$\Pi_{AB} = \{A, B\}, \quad \Pi_{AC} = \{A, C\}.$$

The primary contrast uses only trials with:

$$Q = A.$$

Thus the same policy is selected and executed.

10.2 Factorial randomization

The following are independently randomized:

- initial set S ;
- active versus matched-sham **B**-site intervention;
- delayed policy cue Q ;
- terminal motor mapping;
- object identity;
- and eligible degradation levels.

The initial set is randomized rather than merely counterbalanced by block. Hardware logs verify the full assignment sequence.

10.3 Primary reduced-form estimand

The primary estimand is $\mathcal{D}_B^V$, defined in Section 5.6.

Under licensed-route sensitivity, the intervention effect is expected to be more negative when **B** is licensed than when it is excluded:

$$\mathcal{D}_B^V < 0.$$

Under the exact-minimum model, the corresponding aggregate change is only guaranteed to be:

$$\Delta G_{\min} \leq 0.$$

Strict negativity is predicted only in a preregistered adequate-test subset where:

1. held-out calibration predicts that **B** is or becomes the bottleneck;
2. the intervention changes **B** on licensed-but-unselected trials;
3. the intact **A** route remains within its equivalence bound;
4. the baseline vector lies in an outcome-responsive region established independently;
5. and the excluded-set condition has no corresponding **B** route representation.

10.4 Interpretation of a positive interaction

A positive result would establish that the effect of perturbing the **B** access site depends on whether **B** belongs to the prepared task set. It would rule against the simplest selected-route model if **A** performance and sensory evidence remain stable.

It would remain compatible with:

- a mean over licensed routes;
- a route-weighted resource model;
- generic task-set destabilization;
- state-dependent effective connectivity;
- or a workspace state sensitive to prepared routes.

Only convergent support from Experiment 1 could justify a minimum interpretation.

10.5 Reciprocal **C** experiment

A preregistered replication targets route **C**. The predicted licensing pattern reverses:

- an effect in Π_{AC} ;
- little or no effect in Π_{AB} ;
- with **A** selected in both conditions.

The **B** and **C** experiments are treated as a conjunction for route-general licensing sensitivity. One significant route and one null route do not jointly confirm a route-general rule.

10.6 Equal preparation is not assumed

Even with matched set size and entropy, Π_{AB} and Π_{AC} may differ in preparation cost. The design therefore measures:

- baseline route reliability;

- task-set decoding;
- switching cost;
- cue identification;
- subjective effort;
- and route representational overlap.

Large unmatched set differences do not automatically invalidate the causal interaction because set is randomized, but they weaken the interpretation that route membership rather than broader preparation geometry explains it.

11. Experiment 3: Cardinality and Set Inclusion

11.1 Purpose and secondary status

A separate experiment compares:

$$\{A\}, \quad \{A, B\}, \quad \{A, B, C\}.$$

This experiment is secondary because set size changes cue entropy, preparation load, and route reliabilities.

11.2 Exact-minimum prediction

For fixed component reliabilities:

$$G_{\min}(\{A, B, C\}) \leq G_{\min}(\{A, B\}) \leq G_{\min}(\{A\}).$$

If the added route lies above the existing minimum, the exact aggregate remains unchanged.

11.3 Soft-minimum prediction

The unnormalized soft minimum additionally penalizes cardinality:

$$G_{\text{smin},\lambda} = -\frac{1}{\lambda} \log \sum_{\pi \in \Pi} e^{-\lambda \mu_{\pi}}.$$

Even an added high-reliability route can slightly lower this quantity. The magnitude depends on λ .

Thus, exact minimum and soft minimum make different predictions when an added route is clearly above the existing bottleneck.

11.4 Biological qualification

Set inclusion changes the state that generates each μ_{π} . The analysis therefore compares observed outcomes with aggregates computed from independently measured route vectors under each set. It does not infer the mathematical property directly from raw set-size effects.

12. Experimental Timeline and Measurements

12.1 Trial timeline

A candidate timeline is:

1. fixation: 800–1,200 ms;
2. randomized initial set cue: 400 ms;
3. preparation: 500–800 ms;
4. target onset: $t = 0$;
5. target duration: individually calibrated;
6. backward mask: individually calibrated;
7. preintervention neural interval;
8. route-strength intervention at individualized time;
9. artifact-excluded postintervention interval;
10. delayed policy cue at approximately 550 ms;
11. terminal motor-mapping cue;
12. binary response;
13. visibility rating;
14. confidence rating;
15. occasional identity, phenomenology, or set-memory probe.

The intervention and cue timings are design hypotheses to be calibrated. The supplied temporal records do not validate a universal 180–300 ms transformation window. A theoretical account of content-specific temporal scales likewise does not determine the current TMS interval. ^[10]

12.2 Type-1 sensitivity

Binary choices are modeled using a signal-detection framework separating sensitivity from criterion. On A-selected critical trials, a route-specific interpretation requires practical preservation of A sensitivity.

Response criterion receives its own regression. A change in output bias is not treated as lost visual evidence.

12.3 Visibility

The rating explicitly refers to the perceptual experience of the object before the delayed policy cue. Participants are trained to distinguish:

- perceptual presence;
- confidence in the answer;
- effort;
- and inference from partial features.

This instruction cannot eliminate retrospective reconstruction. The temporal limitation remains.

12.4 Phenomenological probes

On a minority of trials, participants separately rate:

- feature-only versus identity-level experience;
- stability;
- fragmentation;
- inferred versus seen quality;
- effort;
- and bodily salience.

These probes are exploratory construct checks. They are not averaged into a consciousness score.

A multi-indicator approach is preferable to treating one measure as decisive, especially when relating behavior or neural organization to consciousness. [21]

12.5 Posterior sensory representation

Posterior analyses include:

- object-identity decoding;
- policy-bit decoding;
- representational geometry;
- cross-exemplar generalization;
- calibration of trial-level predictions;
- and temporal generalization.

Preserved mean decoding alone is insufficient. Equivalence is assessed for both average performance and representational structure. Even these tests cannot prove that all sensory information is unchanged.

12.6 Route markers

Route markers are defined in the independent localizer and evaluated on held-out trials. They must distinguish:

- the licensed route;
- the selected route;
- transformation content;
- and generic task-set activity.

A pulse-induced reduction in the target marker is interpreted cautiously because source leakage and common-state disruption may mimic route selectivity.

12.7 High-coordination task state

The global neural endpoint is occupancy or dwell time of the independently defined high-coordination state in the artifact-safe interval before Q .

The endpoint is secondary to visibility for the construct claim but essential for temporal interpretation. A pre-cue effect cannot by itself establish consciousness because prospective control can also produce frontoparietal coordination.

12.8 Physiological and ocular variables

Continuous measurements include:

- binocular gaze;
- microsaccades;
- blinks;
- pupil diameter;
- electrocardiography;
- respiration where feasible;
- subjective arousal;
- discomfort;
- and stimulation expectancy.

Pupil and cardiac variables are treated as physiological proxies or covariates. They are not direct measures of precision or locus-coeruleus norepinephrine.

13. Statistical Analysis and Model Comparison

13.1 Analysis populations

Three populations are reported.

1. **Intent-to-train population:** all enrolled participants entering policy learning.
2. **Intent-to-perturb population:** all participants entering the stimulation phase.
3. **Efficacy-qualified population:** participants meeting prespecified route-selectivity and artifact criteria.

The intent-to-perturb analysis is primary for generalizability. The efficacy-qualified analysis is primary for the mechanistic proof of concept. Results are not interpreted interchangeably.

13.2 Route-response model

Selected-route correctness is modeled as:

$$R_{in} \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\mu_{in,Q_{in}}),$$

$$\text{logit}(\mu_{in,\pi}) = a_{i\pi} + f_{\pi}(\mathbf{H}_{in}^{-}) + \sum_r \Omega_{\pi r} U_{in,r} + \sum_{r < r'} \Omega_{\pi r r'} U_{in,r} U_{in,r'} + \boldsymbol{\chi}_{\pi}^{\top} \mathbf{C}_{in}.$$

Participant effects are hierarchically pooled. The model includes the complete cross-route matrix and allows paired-intervention interactions.

The route model is trained independently or cross-fitted by complete session. Trial-adjacent folds are prohibited.

13.3 Aggregator outcome models

Every route-vector model receives the same nuisance structure and an outcome link of matched effective complexity:

$$\eta_{in}^{(g)} = \alpha_i + f^{(g)} [G_g(\widehat{\mu}_{in})] + \beta^\top \mathbf{C}_{in}.$$

Candidate g values are:

- exact minimum;
- mean;
- maximum;
- selected route;
- weighted mean;
- unnormalized soft minimum;
- and, for three-route sets, lower quantile.

The monotone links use the same number of basis functions and similarly regularizing priors. The minimum model does not receive a richer link than its competitors.

13.4 Operational non-route comparators

The following comparators are included without claiming that they exhaust broad consciousness theories.

Sensory model

$$\eta_{in}^{\text{sens}} = \alpha_i + f_{\text{sens}}(D_{in}^{\text{post}}) + \beta^\top \mathbf{C}_{in},$$

where D_{in}^{post} is a held-out posterior sensory score.

Generic task-state model

$$\eta_{in}^{\text{task}} = \alpha_i + f_{\text{task}}(B_{in}) + \beta^\top \mathbf{C}_{in},$$

where B_{in} is an independently measured route-unspecific task-set or coordination variable.

Operational certainty model

$$\eta_{in}^{\text{cert}} = \alpha_i + f_{\text{cert}}(K_{in}) + \beta^\top \mathbf{C}_{in},$$

where K_{in} is a pre-cue certainty marker trained in independent data.

These are predictive parameterizations, not complete global-workspace, higher-order, or predictive-processing theories.

13.5 Primary aggregation decision rule

Support for the exact minimum requires a conjunction:

1. the equal-mean/different-minimum contrast is in the predicted direction;
2. the equal-minimum/different-mean contrast satisfies practical equivalence;

3. bottleneck-rank crossover is recovered from held-out route estimates;
4. the exact-minimum model predicts held-out visibility better than the mean and selected-route models under a recovery-calibrated rule;
5. achieved route vectors match calibration sufficiently for the comparison to be valid.

Failure of any one condition prevents confirmation of the exact minimum. It may still support a broader lower-tail model.

The pre-cue neural endpoint is analyzed with the same contrasts but is not combined with visibility through an unspecified “either-or” rule. Neural convergence strengthens interpretation; neural absence does not automatically erase a valid behavioral aggregation result.

13.6 Primary licensing decision rule

For each reciprocal licensing experiment, the primary endpoint is the ordinal visibility interaction on **A**-selected trials.

A route-general licensing effect requires the predicted interaction for both **B** and **C**, with independently verified target-route changes and preserved intact-route performance. The neural endpoint and metacognition are secondary.

13.7 Equivalence scales

Standardized ordinal effects are expressed in latent probit residual units, where the residual standard deviation is fixed to one. A visibility equivalence region might be:

$$[-0.10, 0.10]$$

latent probit units, but the final bound must be justified by recovery, reliability, and utility simulations before preregistration.

For type-1 sensitivity, equivalence is expressed in d' units. For decoding, it is expressed in absolute balanced-accuracy or area-under-curve units. These scales are never interchanged.

13.8 Bayes-factor specification

If Bayes factors are used for practical equivalence, the competing models are specified in advance.

For an interaction β :

- practical-null model:

$$\beta \sim \text{Uniform}(-\epsilon, \epsilon);$$

- directional alternative:

$$\beta \sim \mathcal{N}(-0.25, 0.20^2) \quad \text{truncated to } \beta < -\epsilon.$$

Nuisance priors, random-effect priors, ordinal-threshold priors, and all stopping rules are fixed. Recruitment uses a fixed sample; no optional stopping is based on the Bayes factor.

A threshold such as $BF_{01} > 10$ is not treated as meaningful until simulation shows its operating characteristics under the complete model.

13.9 Predictive comparison

Expected log predictive density is estimated on held-out sessions. A difference of twice its standard error is treated only as a descriptive heuristic, not a universal evidential boundary.

The final selection rule is calibrated through simulation to control:

- false selection of the minimum;
- false rejection under route correlation;
- sensitivity to criterion shifts;
- sensitivity to missingness;
- and instability under participant heterogeneity.

Model uncertainty is reported. A small predictive advantage does not establish a neural mechanism.

13.10 Sequential mediation

A secondary sequential mediation model examines:

$$\mathbf{U} \rightarrow M_r^+ \rightarrow N \rightarrow V.$$

Route markers are held-out measures, not visibility-derived latent variables. The analysis estimates interventional analogues rather than claiming natural indirect effects under implausible cross-world assumptions.

Identification still requires assumptions about mediator–outcome confounding, measurement error, and temporal ordering. Sensitivity analyses vary each assumption. Mediation is never used to rescue a failed primary contrast.

13.11 Missingness and trial exclusion

Artifact, fixation, and response-time exclusions are determined without access to visibility condition effects. Missing trials are modeled under prespecified missingness scenarios. Sensitivity analyses include:

- missing at random conditional on measured variables;
- intervention-dependent artifact loss;
- and worst-case visibility shifts within excluded trials.

14. Required Recovery Simulations

14.1 Status

No recovery simulation is reported in this manuscript. Completion is mandatory before the confirmatory design is frozen.

14.2 Generative scenarios

Simulations must use the planned:

- participant count;
- sessions and blocks;
- trial allocation;
- route correlations;
- route-intervention matrix;
- paired-site interactions;
- state-estimation noise;
- visibility reliability;
- ordinal criterion variation;
- TMS artifact missingness;
- physiological covariates;
- and participant heterogeneity.

Data must be generated from:

- exact minimum;
- mean;
- maximum;
- selected-route;
- weighted mean;
- soft minimum;
- generic task-set disruption;
- sensory degradation;
- and nonlinear misspecified models.

14.3 Recovery targets

The pipeline must recover:

1. diagonal and off-diagonal route effects;
2. matched-vector identities;
3. bottleneck rank;
4. the equal-mean/different-minimum contrast;
5. the equal-minimum/different-mean equivalence;
6. visibility thresholds separately from latent location;
7. type-1 sensitivity separately from criterion;
8. meta- d' under realistic trial counts;
9. neural state occupancy under artifact loss;
10. model-selection uncertainty.

14.4 Adversarial misspecification

Simulations fitted to data generated by the same model are insufficient. Adversarial scenarios include:

- route reliability depending on an omitted nonlinear state;
- task-set intervention effects not mediated by route reliability;
- heteroscedastic ordinal responses;
- condition-dependent visibility-scale use;
- correlated route-marker errors;
- and intervention-dependent EEG artifact residuals.

If the exact minimum is selected frequently from mean-generated or generic-task-set data, the design is not diagnostic.

14.5 Sample-size determination

The former nominal target of $N = 120$ is retained only as an upper planning reference. Final recruitment is determined by recovery and operating-characteristic simulations, not by a generic standardized-effect calculation.

If a feasible sample cannot distinguish the required vectors, the exact-minimum claim should be narrowed or abandoned.

15. Predictions and Local Rejection Criteria

15.1 Feasibility predictions

A qualifying route intervention should produce:

- a negative diagonal effect on selected-route performance;
- a reduction in the licensed-but-unselected target-route marker;
- off-diagonal behavioral and neural effects within calibrated bounds;
- preserved posterior object representation;
- preserved fixation and arousal measures;
- and no critical effect attributable to pulse sensation or artifact.

Failure rejects the proposed implementation, not necessarily every possible route-aggregation theory.

15.2 Aggregation predictions

The exact-minimum model predicts:

- lower outcome for equal-mean vectors with different minima;
- equivalent outcome for equal-minimum vectors with different means;
- larger effects when the targeted route is or becomes the bottleneck;
- a crossover in marginal intervention sensitivity when bottleneck rank crosses;
- and exact set-inclusion monotonicity when component reliabilities are held fixed.

The mean predicts:

- equality for equal-mean vectors;
- differences for equal-minimum vectors with different means;
- and approximately proportional sensitivity to every route.

15.3 Licensing prediction

For a route-specific intervention on B :

$$\mathcal{D}_B^V \leq 0$$

under a broad lower-tail gate. A strict negative prediction applies only to the independently defined adequate-test subset.

An interaction in the full sample may be attenuated by nonbottleneck and saturated trials. This attenuation is not used post hoc to excuse a null; the qualifying subset and expected attenuation are specified before unblinding.

15.4 When a null is locally decisive

A practical null can reject the specified licensing model only if:

1. the target route is decoded while licensed and unselected;
2. the intervention reduces that marker;
3. selected-route calibration predicts a bottleneck crossing;
4. the vector lies in a response-sensitive range learned independently;
5. the intact route and sensory representation remain stable;
6. the study has demonstrated adequate null sensitivity in simulation.

Selected-route impairment alone does not satisfy these conditions.

15.5 Results that reject the exact minimum

The exact-minimum model is locally rejected if:

- equal-minimum vectors produce reliable outcome differences tracking their means;
- equal-mean vectors fail to differ despite well-separated minima and adequate outcome sensitivity;
- matched decrements affect bottleneck and nonbottleneck routes similarly;
- a mean, weighted mean, or generic task-set model reliably wins held-out recovery-calibrated comparison;
- or the necessary route vectors cannot be recovered with acceptable uncertainty.

15.6 Results that reject route-specific interpretation

A route-specific interpretation is rejected if:

- off-target route effects exceed the equivalence bounds;
- task-set or posterior sensory markers change enough to explain the outcome;
- the same intervention effect appears when the route is excluded;

- or pulse-locked auditory, somatic, or artifact features reproduce the neural result.

15.7 Results that weaken the awareness interpretation

Even if aggregation is identified, the awareness interpretation is weakened if:

- visibility changes only after selected-route errors;
- confidence and effort explain the rating shift;
- identity-present phenomenology remains stable;
- no pre-cue task-state effect occurs;
- or unexpected identity reports remain intact while only arbitrary policy performance changes.

Such a result could still reveal a robust-control computation in prospective task readiness.

16. Alternative Explanations

16.1 Generic task-set destabilization

Stimulation may disrupt a prepared task set rather than a route-specific reliability statistic. This alternative predicts changes in route-unspecific set markers, preparation stability, or both routes.

The full perturbation matrix and independent task-state marker directly test this possibility. A set-dependent pulse effect is not automatically evidence of a minimum.

16.2 State-dependent effective connectivity

A cortical site may influence a distributed network only when its associated route is prepared. The same physical pulse could therefore have a licensed-set interaction without an explicit aggregate computation.

This is a serious alternative. Experiment 1's matched-vector constraints are intended to distinguish a route-reliability functional from unrestricted state dependence, although sufficiently flexible network models may remain observationally equivalent.

16.3 Mean access followed by a nonlinear threshold

A mean can generate categorical-looking effects if passed through a steep nonlinear outcome function. Equal-cardinality licensing does not distinguish that model from the minimum.

Equal-mean/different-minimum and equal-minimum/different-mean vectors are required precisely because nonlinear outcome links cannot create differences between truly equal values of their input without using additional predictors.

16.4 Sensory or attentional impairment

Route-site stimulation may alter feature attention or posterior representation. Average decoding equivalence does not rule out trial-level changes.

The design therefore examines representational geometry, cross-exemplar decoding, ocular state, and sensory mediation. If sensory change accounts for visibility, the route-aggregation interpretation fails.

16.5 Rule memory and working memory

Failure of an arbitrary transformation may reflect loss of the codebook rather than loss of object availability. Overtraining, transfer tests, set-memory probes, and route-specific localizers reduce but do not eliminate this concern.

A positive result must initially be described as involving learned transformation readiness.

16.6 Postdecision reconstruction

Visibility is reported after policy selection and response. Difficulty, error awareness, or confidence may retrospectively change the rating.

Pre-cue neural effects improve temporal ordering but are not independent consciousness assays. A future design may use interleaved immediate-visibility probes, provided the probe itself is included in the licensed-set analysis rather than treated as neutral.

16.7 Rating criterion

Pulse sensation or task expectations may alter scale use. Anchor trials, raw category reporting, threshold sensitivity models, active control, and discomfort ratings address this possibility.

A latent-score result that depends on rigid measurement invariance is not sufficient.

16.8 Unequal policy preparation

Equal set size and cue entropy do not match representational overlap, learning history, switching cost, or susceptibility to stimulation. Those differences are measured rather than assumed absent.

16.9 Resource allocation

A risk-sensitive resource model may prioritize the weakest route without literally computing a minimum. If it reproduces matched-vector equalities and crossovers, the experiment identifies a lower-tail computational regularity but not its implementation.

17. Candidate Neural Interpretation

17.1 Minimal mechanistic claim

The minimal neural claim is that licensed policies instantiate measurable prospective route states before selection and that perturbing one state can alter a later global task-state transition.

This is substantially weaker than asserting a dedicated “minimum neuron” or a constitutive consciousness gate.

17.2 Route and global components

A candidate architecture contains:

1. posterior object representations;
2. policy-selective transformation networks;
3. a task-set maintenance network;

4. a route-sensitive coordination process;
5. and a metastable global task-state process.

Prefrontal state fluctuations and frontoparietal dynamics motivate examining such components, but the supplied evidence does not assign them these computational roles. ^{[7] [20]}

17.3 Neural-mass sketch

For neural population j :

$$\tau_j \frac{dx_j(t)}{dt} = -x_j(t) + \phi_j \left[\sum_{\ell} w_{j\ell} x_{\ell}(t) + I_j(t) + \xi_j(t) \right].$$

Licensing can modulate effective connectivity from the task-set network to route R_{π} :

$$w_{R_{\pi},T}(t) = \ell_{\pi} \tilde{w}_{R_{\pi},T},$$

where $\ell_{\pi} = 1$ when route π is licensed.

A route intervention is represented as a transient change in the target population or its effective coupling. The sign and spatial extent are empirical; TMS is not assumed to be simply inhibitory.

17.4 Possible lower-tail implementation

An unnormalized soft minimum could be implemented approximately by competitive populations:

$$G_{\text{min},\lambda} = -\lambda^{-1} \log \sum_{\pi} e^{-\lambda \hat{\mu}_{\pi}}.$$

A weak route contributes more strongly to the sum because $e^{-\lambda \hat{\mu}_{\pi}}$ is larger for lower reliability. This supplies a computational sketch, not evidence for a circuit.

Other implementations include:

- max pooling over route-specific error signals;
- divisive inhibition dominated by the least stable route;
- or risk-sensitive recurrent control.

Behavioral minimum-like constraints would not distinguish these mechanisms.

17.5 No single validated ignition composite

The revised protocol does not combine amplitude, recruitment, phase coordination, and state occupancy into an outcome chosen after inspection. Features and weights are fixed independently.

The neural result remains vulnerable to the prerequisite–substrate–consequence problem emphasized in oscillatory consciousness research. ^[22]

18. Emotion, Arousal, and Interoception

18.1 Restricted role

Emotion and interoception are not part of the primary confirmatory aggregation test. They enter as measured covariates and later randomized moderators.

Emotion can influence perception, attention, learning, memory, reasoning, and action in context-dependent directions. ^[3] Emotional arousal and valence have also been investigated in relation to access to visual awareness, although the supplied title-level records do not establish a common mechanism. ^[30] ^[31]

18.2 Noradrenergic selectivity hypothesis

The GANE model proposes that norepinephrine hotspots amplify prioritized representations while suppressing weaker representations. ^[28] If such selective gain operates in this task, arousal could increase the strongest route while decreasing a weaker one.

That pattern would be especially consequential for a lower-tail aggregator. It remains a theoretical moderator, not evidence for the minimum.

18.3 Interoceptive models

Active interoceptive inference links bodily regulation, uncertainty, precision, neuromodulation, emotion, and selfhood. ^[2] A formal cardiac active-inference model uses simulations to connect cardiac signals with exteroceptive perception and uncertainty. ^[29] An interoceptive predictive-coding account associates conscious presence with successful top-down suppression of informative interoceptive signals or prediction errors and proposes an anterior-insula comparator role. ^[27]

These sources motivate hypotheses. They do not validate pupil diameter, cardiac phase, or heart-rate variability as direct trial-level precision measurements. The variables are modeled with competing arousal, effort, discomfort, and orienting explanations.

19. Philosophical Interpretation

19.1 A task-indexed interventionist disposition

If Experiments 1 and 2 succeed, prospective reportability would be usefully characterized as an interventionist disposition. A represented object would support a family of experimentally realizable delayed-cue interventions, including policies never selected on that trial.

This is more informative than defining reportability by the response that happened to occur. It is also more restricted than quantifying over every conceivable question or action.

19.2 Robustness versus ordinary capacity

Under an ordinary capacity-based description, a content remains reportable if route **A** still supports a correct answer. The minimum proposal applies a stricter standard: every currently licensed route must remain sufficiently reliable.

The manuscript does not redefine ordinary reportability by fiat. It distinguishes:

- **single-route report capacity;**
- **prospective multi-policy reportability;**
- and **subjective visibility judgment.**

The experiments ask whether the second predicts the third.

19.3 Context dependence

The same posterior object representation may be embedded in different prospective task states under Π_{AB} and Π_{AC} . If route **B** is weak, the minimum differs across sets even when **A** remains intact.

This context dependence is internal to the participant's represented task. An unencoded laboratory instruction does not enter the licensed set.

19.4 Relation to global availability

If a lower-tail rule is supported, "availability" could be refined as a vector of route-specific intervention reliabilities rather than a binary architectural label. A workspace-like system might stabilize only when that vector meets a robustness condition.

Such a result would be compatible with a workspace architecture. It would not validate global-workspace theory as a whole or show that all global availability is minimum-based.

19.5 Relation to higher-order representation

A higher-order system could represent the reliability vector or its lower tail. Conversely, a lower-tail computation could occur without a distinct higher-order representation.

The empirical contribution would be a computational constraint. Architectural interpretation would remain underdetermined.

19.6 Predictive processing

Predictive processing may provide a principled language for mapping neural and phenomenological structure while remaining neutral among consciousness theories. ^[1] Route reliabilities could be interpreted as predictions about successful policy-conditioned action, but predictive processing does not independently select the minimum.

19.7 Phenomenal consciousness

At least four interpretations remain possible after a positive result:

1. robust multi-policy reportability partly constitutes access consciousness;
2. it is a prerequisite for stable access but not its substrate;
3. it affects introspective access and postdecision visibility while first-order phenomenology remains stable;
4. it is an executive robustness computation only contingently correlated with visibility.

The current experiment cannot distinguish these possibilities conclusively.

A scalar route aggregate cannot represent qualitative color, shape, spatial structure, unity, temporal flow, or embodied presence. It is, at most, one proposed control variable within a richer organization of experience.

19.8 Temporal structure

A theoretical synaptic-clock proposal emphasizes that conscious contents have nonzero duration and may operate over content-specific temporal scales.^[10] The current design is compatible with temporally extended state formation, but that source does not validate the chosen pulse times.

Any observed transition should be described as a task-state change over a calibrated interval, not as the exact onset or duration of a conscious moment.

20. Limitations

20.1 No pilot or recovery evidence

The most immediate limitation is evidential. The manuscript does not provide the route-selectivity pilot, TMS–EEG validation, or completed recovery simulations requested by the reviewers. The protocol is consequently not confirmatory-ready.

20.2 Conditional response surfaces are model-dependent

Randomization identifies intervention distributions and average effects. Continuous-state conditional response surfaces require smoothing, overlap, and transport assumptions. Exact individual-trial counterfactual probabilities remain unavailable.

20.3 The route manipulation may be infeasible

Arbitrary learned transformations may not have sufficiently separable or stable cortical access sites. A route-specific behavioral effect may coexist with broad network changes. If so, the proposed causal isolation fails.

20.4 Paired route manipulation is technically demanding

Experiment 1 requires independent variation of at least two route strengths. Paired-site stimulation may create nonlinear interactions, unmatched sensations, or excessive artifacts. Independent calibration can diagnose these problems but not guarantee a solution.

20.5 Visibility remains postdecision

Visibility is rated after delayed selection and response. Scale instructions, intact-route restriction, and pre-cue neural measures reduce but do not remove postdecision contamination.

20.6 Neural state is not a consciousness measure

A label-free high-coordination state avoids direct circularity, but it may reflect prospective control, working memory, or task-set maintenance. The neural endpoint provides timing and mechanism constraints, not independent proof of awareness.

20.7 Arbitrary mappings increase executive demands

The design isolates transformations at the cost of ecological validity. A positive result may be specific to overlearned but artificial codebooks.

20.8 Identity-level coding may remain incomplete

Cross-exemplar transfer and unexpected identity probes reduce direct feature-to-bit shortcuts, but no finite test proves that participants represent identity in the same form across every route.

20.9 Outcome links may obscure aggregator differences

Even matched-vector designs depend on adequate vector separation, outcome sensitivity, and measurement reliability. Flexible links can overfit, whereas restrictive links can unfairly favor one model. Matched complexity and recovery tests reduce but do not eliminate this tradeoff.

20.10 Threshold language remains tempting

A steep nonlinear outcome function may look threshold-like. The revision avoids calling its transition an awareness threshold, but interpretive pressure may remain. Curvature in a rating model is not evidence for a discrete conscious state.

20.11 Theory-level underdetermination

A lower-tail regularity could be implemented by workspace, higher-order, predictive, recurrent-control, resource-allocation, or robust-decision architectures. Predictive superiority of one parameterization does not uniquely select a consciousness theory.

20.12 Physiological proxies are ambiguous

Pupil, cardiac, respiratory, and subjective-arousal variables have multiple determinants. They cannot identify neural precision without a validated measurement model.

20.13 Efficacy qualification changes the estimand

A sample restricted to participants with localizable and perturbable routes estimates an effect among perturbable participants. It does not support population-wide claims.

20.14 Exact minimum may be the wrong lower-tail model

Biological control may use a soft minimum, quantile, or reliability bound. The exact minimum is retained because it yields discriminating constraints, not because it is assumed neurally privileged.

20.15 Reportability is not phenomenal consciousness

A vivid object could remain phenomenally present while one arbitrary route fails. The experiment must not be used to deny such experience. This is the central philosophical and ethical limitation.

21. Clinical, Comparative, and Artificial-System Extensions

21.1 Disorders of consciousness

Computational modeling in disorders of consciousness aims to improve diagnosis, causal understanding, patient stratification, and intervention design, while substantial gaps remain between current methods and mature personalized models. ^[4]

If the healthy-participant paradigm were validated, route-vector methods might eventually contribute to individualized assessments of covert command following across several output channels. Such an extension would require independent accommodation of:

- language impairment;
- motor disconnection;
- fatigue;
- sensory loss;
- memory impairment;
- and task comprehension.

A weak route must never be equated with absence of phenomenal consciousness.

21.2 Animal studies

A task-local licensing design could use saccadic, orienting, or learned choice policies in nonhuman animals. Global-workspace ideas remain relevant to animal consciousness if a core broadcast mechanism is shared, but that possibility is empirical rather than established by philosophical argument alone. ^[14]

Counterfactual route sensitivity would be one indicator among many. Multi-indicator approaches caution against treating a single behavior or neural measure as decisive. ^[21]

21.3 Artificial systems

Artificial agents can be tested directly by licensing several readout transformations, perturbing one unselected module, and measuring effects on shared internal states and later reports. Passing such a test would demonstrate a form of robust task-conditioned organization.

It would not establish machine consciousness. Contemporary theory-derived assessments emphasize multiple computational indicators and uncertainty rather than one decisive test. ^[12]

21.4 Diverse embodied systems

A technological approach to diverse minds advocates continuous, empirically grounded study across biological and synthetic embodiments. ^[25] Route reliability is substrate-neutral as a formal quantity, but its psychological interpretation depends on the system's body, learning history, ecology, and available actions.

22. Ethical and Communication Commitments

22.1 Participant safety

TMS, MRI, EEG, and related procedures require institutional review, contraindication screening, informed consent, trained supervision, and stopping rules. The paired-site and repeated-session burden must be justified by feasibility data before confirmatory recruitment.

22.2 No consciousness denial from route failure

A low minimum can result from:

- poor policy learning;
- rule-memory failure;
- focal executive disruption;
- language or motor impairment;
- or an artificial task bottleneck.

It does not establish absence of seeing, pain, emotion, or phenomenal experience.

22.3 No clinical decision use

The proposed statistic should not guide withdrawal of care, legal status, or treatment limitation. Clinical modeling remains promising but incomplete. ^[4]

22.4 No single-test verdict for artificial systems

A machine could implement a minimum without experience. An experiencing system could organize access differently. Passing or failing the proposed test is neither necessary nor sufficient for consciousness.

22.5 Public reporting language

If the licensing interaction alone is positive, the appropriate statement is:

Perturbing an unselected prepared route changed later visibility judgment or pre-cue task-state dynamics only when that route was licensed.

If matched-vector evidence also supports a lower-tail rule, the statement may add:

The pattern was better captured by a lower-tail route-reliability functional than by mean or selected-route reliability.

Only after broader construct validation should the result be discussed as evidence about reportable visual awareness. It should not be described as the mechanism of phenomenal consciousness.

23. Conclusion

This revised manuscript proposes an identifiability-first test of how several prospective report routes are combined before delayed response selection. Its central methodological distinction remains useful: a route can be licensed, causally perturbed, left unselected, and never executed on the same trial. That separation permits a direct test of whether an unrealized but prepared report transformation influences later visibility judgment and pre-cue task-state dynamics.

The revised framework no longer treats delayed-cue randomization as identifying both potential outcomes for one exact trial. It defines route accessibility through conditional and marginal response surfaces:

$$\mu_{i\pi}(\mathbf{u}, s, \mathbf{h}) = \Pr[R_{in}(\mathbf{u}, Q = \pi) = 1 \mid S = s, \mathbf{H}^- = \mathbf{h}],$$

estimated from independent or cross-fitted selected-route data. Trial-level values are predictions, not observed counterfactual properties.

The principal aggregation hypothesis is:

$$G_{\min}(\boldsymbol{\mu}) = \min_{\pi \in \Pi} \mu_{\pi}.$$

Testing this rule requires more than a set-by-perturbation interaction. The revised Experiment 1 independently varies at least two route strengths and creates approximately equal-mean/different-minimum, equal-minimum/different-mean, and bottleneck-crossover conditions. Experiment 2 then tests whether an unselected route matters specifically when licensed. A positive licensing interaction supports counterfactual route sensitivity; it supports a minimum only when combined with the vector constraints.

The former participant-specific awareness threshold and disconnected latent awareness state have been removed. Visibility is modeled as an anchored ordinal judgment, and neural state structure is learned independently without visibility labels. The finite normalized soft minimum has also been removed because it does not preserve exact set-inclusion monotonicity. Exact minimum and unnormalized soft minimum are treated as distinct models.

The proposal remains contingent on an unresolved empirical premise. No supplied source shows that arbitrary learned report transformations can be selectively perturbed in the required pre-cue interval while preserving the intact route, posterior sensory evidence, task-set representation, ocular state, arousal, and artifact-safe EEG. Demonstrating such perturbability is the first scientific result the program must obtain. Completed recovery simulations are equally necessary before sample size and decision rules can be frozen.

If the full program succeeds, the warranted conclusion would be limited but informative: prospective task readiness is sensitive to an unselected licensed route, and later visibility judgment or pre-cue task-state dynamics follow a lower-tail reliability constraint rather than merely the selected route or average performance. That result could refine computational accounts of flexible access.

It would not establish that visual phenomenology disappears when one arbitrary transformation fails. It would not identify a universal awareness threshold, select a unique consciousness theory, or settle the structure of phenomenal consciousness. The strongest present claim is therefore methodological: a credible worst-route hypothesis must be tested through independently calibrated route vectors, bottleneck crossovers, explicit alternative models, artifact-sensitive feasibility work, and local rejection rules—not inferred from a single licensed-set interaction.

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Peer Review Notes

- **juno-park:** The manuscript is conceptually original, unusually transparent about its speculative status, and stronger than most consciousness proposals in its use of reciprocal perturbation, explicit alternatives, and prospective falsification criteria. However, the core model is not presently identifiable: the participant threshold is algebraically confounded with outcome intercepts, the latent awareness variable is disconnected from the observation model, and trial-specific counterfactual route probabilities cannot be recovered merely by randomizing one delayed cue. The normalized soft-min implementation also violates the exact model's set-inclusion monotonicity at finite temperature. Empirically, no supplied source establishes that arbitrary learned report transformations can be selectively perturbed before cue selection while preserving the executed route and posterior sensory evidence. Finally, although phenomenal consciousness is verbally protected, the operational target shifts between visual awareness, postdecision visibility judgment, and robust competence across arbitrary binary policies.
- **minseo-vale:** The manuscript presents a genuinely novel, unusually explicit, and potentially falsifiable distinction among licensed, selected, and executed report policies. Most elementary minimum-operator derivations are correct, and the repeated restriction of the claim to reportable rather than phenomenal consciousness is commendable. However, the proposed licensed-set-by-TMS interaction is not diagnostic of minimum aggregation, the trial-level counterfactual accessibilities are not identified without strong structural assumptions, and the awareness threshold is algebraically unidentifiable in the stated observation models. Several citations support only title-level topical claims, one citation is a poor fit, and the crucial feasibility of route-selective pre-cue TMS with uncontaminated EEG readout is unsupported by the supplied records.